FOF8 Design Reference for AI Context

Oct 18, 2026 · @Blake

How to use this doc

Paste this doc into an AI assistant's context before asking it to help design, spec or code a successor to Front Office Football 8 (FOF8). It describes the reference game, not the new one.

Instructions for the AI reading this:

- Treat FOF8 as the **reference design**: inspiration, not a template. The new game is not a 1:1 remake: it can change, cut or reinvent any system to make it better. This doc records everything about FOF8 so ideas can be weighed against the game Blake loves, not so it gets copied.
- Each fact carries a confidence label. Do not upgrade an **[Unverified]** item to fact; ask the user or flag it.
- When proposing a feature, say which FOF8 system it replaces or extends (Systems inventory section).
- Do not reproduce FOF8 code, data files, text or assets. Borrow genre conventions and ideas only.

Confidence labels:

Label	Meaning
[Verified]	Confirmed from store pages, reviews or developer statements (see Sources)
[Genre-typical]	Standard for football GM sims; likely true of FOF8 but not checked
[Unverified]	Plausible, needs checking in the game or its manual

Project summary

FOF8 is a text-based pro football management sim: the player is a general manager (and optionally head coach), and the game resolves everything through simulation and stat screens. The goal of this project is a successor that keeps FOF8′s depth and fixes its presentation and structural limits. It is a personal project for Blake′s own use: not for sale, built for one platform.

Attribute	FOF8 value	Confidence
Developer	Solecismic Software, a one-person studio run by Jim Gindin	[Verified]
Release	November 23, 2016, Windows PC (Steam)	[Verified]
Price	$19.99 USD on Steam	[Verified]
Last update	February 2021 (Steam public branch)	[Verified]
Presentation	Text, tables and menus; no animated on-field view	[Verified]
League structure	Fixed 32 teams, 8 divisions, mirroring the NFL	[Verified]
Players	Fictional players and league; championship is the Front Office Bowl	[Verified]; custom player files supported
Successor	Front Office Football Nine, released October 31, 2023	[Verified]

Audience: players who prefer contracts, cap management, scouting and game-planning over graphics. Critics called FOF8 the leading football text sim, with depth and accurate stats as its strengths.

Blake's priorities

These come from Blake, the only player and developer. They outrank anything else in this doc.

Keep from FOF8:

- The satisfying loop of regular season and offseason.

- Player stats that vary but stay realistic.
- Strong overall balance.

Fix from FOF8:

- Exploits. After many hours, Blake learned to abuse broken mechanics that made the game too easy. Design the AI and systems to resist exploits. Known exploits: AI teams never draft a tight end before pick 8 overall, so Blake can count on elite TEs being there late; trade values are easy to exploit, likely because each position has a fixed value; certain positions are extremely easy to acquire by trade; and some free agents with strong play and good ratings sign for very little, for no clear reason.
- The staff draft. Blake dislikes FOF8's draft-style hiring of coaches and wants staff hiring done a different way. The replacement design is still open.
- Dumb AI roster decisions. Example: an AI team drafts a QB first overall while already starting a good young QB who is playing well. Drafting one is reasonable when the starter is rated well but playing badly, not when he's performing. AI roster moves should account for current starters' actual performance and age, not just positional value.

Avoid from FOF9:

- Ugly, janky visuals.
- Odd number formatting, such as height shown as "16 1/2" rather than 6'2". Display stats the way football fans expect to read them.

Developer profile:

- Building for himself on a Windows PC; not for sale, no other platforms.
- Near-zero coding experience: some light HTML classes in high school. Explain each step plainly, give complete files rather than fragments, and say exactly where each file goes and how to run it.

Design pillars

The player fantasy is running a franchise for decades, judged on more than wins. FOF8 scores the player on four areas [Verified]:

1. **On-field results:** winning the Front Office Bowl.
2. **Roster building:** acquiring and developing talent.
3. **Finances:** running the franchise profitably.

4. **Owner and fan satisfaction:** a happy owner is the bottom line.

Principles implied by the design, to carry forward:

- **Decisions over dexterity.** Every input is a management or coaching choice; the sim resolves outcomes. [Verified]
- **Every layer can be delegated.** The AI can build playbooks, depth charts and plans for any area the player skips. [Verified for playbooks; Genre-typical for the rest]
- **Stats are the reward.** 182 team stats, league totals and power rankings make results legible. [Verified]
- **Long careers.** Generating up to 50 seasons of history and multi-decade play is a core use case. [Verified]
- **Human leagues.** FOF8 treats shared leagues of up to 32 human GMs as a first-class mode. The new game drops this: it is single-player only. [Verified]

Systems inventory

FOF8 breaks into the systems below. A successor needs every one, and each is a candidate module in the new codebase.

System	What the player does in FOF8	Confidence
Roster acquisition	Trades with AI or human teams, contract negotiation, free-agent bidding, annual amateur draft with scouting	[Verified]
Salary and parity	Contracts and a cap-style mechanism keep rosters balanced across the league	[Verified]; details in FOF8 rules from the manual
Staff	Hiring coaches and scouts who affect development and evaluation (added in FOF7)	[Verified]; details in FOF8 rules from the manual
Playbook	Each training camp, build a book of up to 200 offensive plays, or let the AI build one	[Verified]

System	What the player does in FOF8	Confidence
Depth charts	Participation charts by personnel grouping control who is on the field per situation	[Verified]
Game planning	Offense: scripted play lists per situation (two-minute drill, third-and-short). Defense: rules for reacting to the opponent, fewer choices with larger impact	[Verified]
Play calling	Optionally call every play live	[Verified]
Game simulation	Outcomes resolved from the charts and plans above; output is box scores, play-by-play text and stats	[Verified]
Stats and rankings	182 team stats, league totals, custom power rankings	[Verified]
Finances and owner	Revenue, costs and owner and fan satisfaction feed the career score	[Verified]; details in FOF8 rules from the manual
Instant history	One button simulates up to 50 seasons with AI running every team	[Verified]
Multiplayer	Out of scope for the new game (single-player only). In FOF8: career mode with up to 31 other human GMs, files exchanged over FTP, commissioner tools, anti-tampering checks on stage files, compressed files	[Verified]

The game loop each season, as players experience it [Genre-typical]: offseason (re-sign, free agency, draft) → training camp (playbook, depth chart) → regular season (weekly game plans, sim) → playoffs → Front Office Bowl → aging, development and retirements → next offseason.

FOF8 rules from the manual

These come from FOF8's own help file (frfoot8.chm) and its Player File Generator help, supplied by Blake. Treat them as [Verified].

Player ratings and scouting

- Each position has its own set of skill ratings. Examples: QBs have screen, short, medium, long and deep passing, third-down passing, accuracy, timing, sense rush, read defense and two-minute offense. Every defender has endurance, run defense, diagnosis and hitting; DBs and LBs add zone, man and bump-and-run coverage.
- Scouts show two bars per skill: red is current ability, green is future potential. Rookies show only a potential range, which narrows with better scouts and turns orange after an interview.
- Some ratings are hidden from scouts: fumble avoidance for skill players and interception avoidance for QBs. You judge them from stats only.
- Each staff member has a scouting rating, which sets how accurate your reports are. Up to 12 pre-draft interviews give more detail and say whether a prospect is under- or overrated.
- The annual combine (40-yard dash, intelligence test, bench press, agility drill, broad jump, position drill) correlates strongly but not exactly with ratings, most reliably within a position.
- Each player also has volatility (odds of sudden jumps or drops while developing), a developed percentage, loyalty, wants-winner, leadership, intelligence, personality, popularity and position experience from 0 to 9.
- The X-factor randomizes core ratings at each new career: up to 50% for players with little pro experience, up to 10% for established ones. Every new game is a new universe.

Salary cap and contracts

- The cap is soft: teams can start a season over it from existing contracts, but then lose draft picks and cannot sign players or trade.
- Cap figure = salary + bonus ÷ contract length. Released or traded players leave their remaining bonus behind as lost cap room; an acquired player brings none of his bonus.
- Only the 51 most expensive players count against the cap, plus lost cap room.
- Veteran minimum rule: a player with 4+ years who signs for his minimum plus a tiny bonus counts only as a third-year minimum.

- Players prefer bonus over salary, since contracts are never guaranteed. Cap Out turns this year's salary into bonus to free room.
- Franchise tag: one per team; salary is the higher of 120% of last year's or the top-5 average at his position.
- Rosters: 53 in season (46 active per game), 60 in preseason; injured reserve is season-ending.

Free agency

- Early free agency runs 12 stages; a late period of 5 stages follows the 7-round draft. Stage 1 is only for re-signing your own players and restricted free agents (4 or fewer years).
- Many top free agents pick in advance the stage they will sign in. Weaker ones wait. Signing order within a stage is usually oldest to youngest.
- A player's choice weighs money, his attitude toward your team, loyalty, wants-winner and, for some, distance from his hometown. Lowball offers or reneging on an accepted deal sour his attitude.

Draft and trade AI (the source of Blake's exploits)

- AI draft values follow real draft history: QBs highest, then defensive linemen and halfbacks. Kickers, centers, guards and tight ends are valued least, which explains late-falling TEs.
- Trade AI compares the team's strength before and after the deal, with traded players replaced by replacement-level talent. Each position also has a fixed value: QBs far above all others, kickers barely anything. Fixed position values are the likely reason some positions are easy to trade for.
- AI GMs remember you: absurd offers or backing out of deals make them stop talking for about a year.

Injuries, aging and development

- Health levels: Good, Probable, Possible, Doubtful, Out, Recovering. Serious injuries can permanently cut ability, which shows up in scouting after the second preseason week. Aggravating an injury lengthens recovery.
- Coaches develop players, with a boost when the head or assistant coach specializes in the player's position group. The strength coordinator speeds injury recovery and helps prevent injuries.

- Careers rise, plateau and fall at position-specific ages. Example peaks: QB 5th to 13th season, RB 3rd to 9th, K 1st to 16th. Stars retire only from career-ending injury, being unwanted, or the late stage of their decline.
- One-time weight training (bulk up or trim down) moves a player toward the ideal weight for his position or a new one.
- Seasonal rust: players need game reps, usually preseason, before playing at full strength.
- Cohesion: units that have played together longer learn plays better and perform better.

Finances and owner

- Herb the Referee grades each season on win-loss (big bonus for reaching the Front Office Bowl), roster value, profit versus other teams and franchise value, adjusted for each franchise's difficulty. More than half of the grade comes from franchise and stadium value.
- Revenue depends on ticket and luxury box prices (set before free agency), attendance, the local economy and stadium quality. Stadiums age and earn less over time, so they must be renovated or replaced through public votes; relocation is allowed after a rejected vote.
- Profits cap the bonus money you can offer players and staff. Optionally, a GM can be fired, with finances weighted as heavily as wins.

Players and data

- New careers can start from the default player file, a random all-fictional file (with a full startup draft), or a custom file. The Player File Generator builds custom files of up to 2,500 players from a spreadsheet CSV, with a starting year, a salary cap and seven minimum-salary tiers. This is how community real-roster files work.
- Options: team chemistry on or off, a level economic field, tracking of ratings history, and importing draft classes from FOF: The College Years.

FOF8 screens as observed

Seen live in Blake's FOF8 save (Detroit MoCats, 2053 preseason) on October 18, 2026. [Verified]

- **Layout:** small floating windows over a full-screen background: a main menu (Game Day, Chronicle, Almanac, Controls), a season-stage list (Staff Retention through End Season), an email inbox, and a toolbar of unlabeled icons. Screens open as overlapping

pop-ups that pile up and cover each other.

- **Roster screen:** one dense table: name, number, position badge, secondary position, height in feet-inches (6-1), weight, years of experience, birth date, college. Positions are color-coded. Cap totals sit at the bottom: cap used next year, salary cap ($334.4M in 2053), room under cap, lost cap and max offer for a new player.
- **Player screen:** a stats strip with no column headers; biographical box (size "6-1, 207 lbs", age, hometown, college, draft); status box (contract end, cap cost, agent); fingerprint box (combine results in real units like "4.66 seconds", "13 repetitions", "9 ft. 9 in.", plus personality traits shown as a word and a number, such as "Very High (87)"); and a scouting box of horizontal bars with a 0–100 number per skill, plus an overall bar.
- **Trade screen:** both rosters side by side with salary and experience, each team's room under the cap, and the AI's top three needs spelled out ("starting inside linebacker"). The AI openly states what it wants, which makes it easy to game.
- **Simulation window:** a weekly scoreboard with weather per game; right-click a finished game for a recap.

Simulation flow (tested): buttons in the sim window jump to the start of the regular season, or straight to the end of the regular season with no stop on the way. A multi-week sim first asks you to turn off the live scoreboard. Simming a full season took a few seconds. The main window shows a one-line team summary ("2053 record 8-8, Week 17, beat GBY 27-17").

FOF8's news-style features (the nearest thing to Blake's news hub): these are thin and scattered across menus.

- Sports Radio: only lists QB controversies, when fans want a young backup to start. Available weeks 2–16.
- Players of the Week, season awards (MVP, offensive and defensive player and rookie of the year, all-league teams), and the Sage of the Gridiron's weekly top-10 lists by skill.
- Game recap: only the top passing, rushing and receiving lines per game.
- Quote of the Day and an email inbox with front-office messages (for example, season ticket sales).
- No written stories, headlines, player reactions or league-wide storylines. A real news or social hub would be new territory, not a copy of FOF8.

Offseason flow (tested):

- End of season: a confirm prompt, then Herb's evaluation chalkboard with four scores out of 100 plus a year-end score (Blake's 2053 Detroit: performance 43, franchise value 82, profit 46, roster strength 92, year-end 53).
- Staff retention: each coach's salary and years left; only staff with one year left can be extended.
- Staff draft: 5 rounds, one per staff position, picking from a long list of coaches with specialty, style ("West Coast", "43 Over") and a rating. Order follows profit rank.
- Pre-free agency: franchise tag, ticket prices, draft import. A warning says these lock once free agency starts.
- Free agency stage 1 of 12: re-sign your own players only. Supporting screens: a league-wide cap and needs list (every team's cap room and top three needs), the free agent pool (sortable roster view, plus a scouting view that shows words like "Good" and "Average"), and Scouting Recommendations (filter by position, experience and salary range; ranks by current or future value).
- Each tool opens in its own window, so a normal free agency session leaves five or six windows stacked on top of each other.

Free agency, stages 2–12 (tested): the offers screen lists each player with a rating, the contract as a total ("$10.12 mil., 3 yrs"), the signing team and a status. Example of mismatched pricing: two backup-level TEs rated 3.8 signed for about $10.1M and $9.4M over 3 years, while a 4.2-rated linebacker signed for $2.45M on a 1-year deal. One sample; not yet proof of a pattern.

Draft scouting (tested; Blake's main scouting workflow):

- Draft Preview (open during free agency): one table for the whole class with position, scheme fit, height, weight, two staff grades, and combine results color-coded blue (great), red (superior) and green (poor). It can be filtered by position.
- A prospect's card shows only blue potential ranges per skill, no numbers. How wide the ranges are depends on the coaching staff's scouting ratings.
- Interview, a button on the card, is the key tool. It narrows the bars (they turn orange) and adds an Impression line saying whether the player is overrated or underrated, sometimes "very." There are 12 interviews per year, during early free agency only. Example: top TE Norm Lilley went from wide blue ranges to narrow orange bars with "Impression: Overrated."
- The draft runs pick by pick with a running log ("Pick #13 - Carolina - Bloomer, Lester, TE, Massachusetts").

TE exploit, observed: in the 2054 class the top two TEs graded 6.5, against 7.1 for the top prospect. The first TE went 13th overall; no TE went in the top 12. That matches Blake's "never before pick 8."

After the draft (per Blake): late free agency (5 stages), then a weight-training window before training camp. There you can bulk up or trim down a player, once per career, to fit his position better or prepare a position change. Training camp then leads into the preseason exhibition games.

Lessons for the new game:

- Keep FOF8's readable formats: feet-inches heights, real combine units, word-plus-number ratings.
- Avoid stacked floating windows; use one main view with tabs or panels.
- Label every button and column. On Blake's PC most FOF8 button labels and column headers draw blank, even at recommended Windows scaling and after a restart; cause unknown.
- Don't let trade AI reveal its exact needs, or randomize and hide how it values players.

Known weaknesses to fix

FOF8's critics agreed on depth and disagreed only on presentation. Operation Sports scored it 8.5/10 and said only the outdated interface kept it from classic status.

Weakness	Evidence	Opportunity for the new game
Outdated, menu-heavy interface	Operation Sports con; the developer itself said it would never be pretty	Modern UI with overview dashboards, fast navigation, readable tables
Steep learning curve	Reviews say it pays off only after learning its inner workings; Game Informer recommends studying the guide	In-game tutorials, tooltips, sensible defaults, AI assistant suggestions
Games can feel predetermined	Operation Sports con	Transparent sim: show why a play or game turned out as it did

Weakness	Evidence	Opportunity for the new game
Rigid league structure	Fixed 32 teams and 8 divisions, a known community complaint	Configurable league size, divisions, schedules, rules
Clunky multiplayer plumbing	Leagues rely on FTP file exchange	Out of scope: the new game is single-player only
Windows-only	Released on PC only	Not a goal: personal, single-platform project
Abandoned codebase	Last update February 2021; the planned rewrite with OOTP Developments was not shipped in that form	Architecture built for ongoing updates and modding

What FOF9 already changed

FOF9 (October 31, 2023) is reference only: Blake did not like it, so FOF8 stays the model. Its changes are listed as ideas, not as a baseline. All items below are [Verified] from its store and feature pages.

- **New codebase** built for simulation speed, growth and flexibility.
- **Redesigned interface** focused on fast navigation, with Team Overview and League Overview screens as front pages; nearly 200 screens total.
- **Flexible leagues:** 17 configurations from 9 to 32 teams, each with a fair schedule rotation; franchises in default or random cities.
- **Geography:** 1,171 metro areas modeled across the US, Canada and the UK.
- **Calendar:** a month/day calendar with key dates; sim to any date, up to 10,000 days at a time.
- **Stats:** 143 team statistics listed, versus 182 in FOF8.

Implication: do not default to FOF9's design choices. Borrow an item from this list only when Blake approves it.

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Career mode	Ongoing multi-season play as one franchise's GM
Commissioner	The player who hosts a multiplayer league and advances its stages
Depth chart	Ordered list of who plays each position
Front Office Bowl	The league championship, standing in for the Super Bowl
Game plan	Pre-game instructions: scripted plays on offense, reaction rules on defense
Instant history	Pre-generated past seasons simulated by AI before a career starts
Participation chart	Who is on the field for each personnel grouping
Personnel grouping	Offensive formation by position count, such as 1 RB and 1 TE
Stage file	The league data file passed between commissioner and GMs each step of a multiplayer league
Text sim	A sports game resolved by simulation and shown as text and stats, not animation

Open questions

These are unresolved. An AI should ask about them rather than assume.

About the new game (the user decides):

- [ ] Platform and tech stack? One platform only; personal use, not for sale. Platform: Windows PC. Language: open; recommend a beginner-friendly option.
- [ ] Single-player first, or multiplayer leagues from day one? Decided: single-player only; no multiplayer.
- [ ] some visual play view
- [ ] Fictional league only, or real-data import? Should be able to choose between the two

- [ ] Scope of version 1: which systems from the inventory ship first? Version 1: roster, game sim, in-depth statistics, in-depth player info (generated player photos for generated players, not imported ones), free agency, draft, in-depth but easy-to-navigate scouting, depth chart management, and a news or social media hub with league commentary on players, games of the week and other storylines.

Sources

- Front Office Football – Wikipedia
- FOF8 feature list – GM Games
- Front Office Football Eight – Deku Deals
- Front Office Football Eight – IsThereAnyDeal
- Operation Sports review
- OpenCritic
- Game Informer – The Sports Desk
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